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Kinship and marriage among the Nuer

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A son-in-law also respects his parents-in-law by hiding his nakedness in their presence with a wild cat's skin from the day he asks for their daughter's hand in marriage till the day his brother receives a cow to enable him to eat in their home. While the prohibition is in force a son-in-law who is living in the same village or camp as his parents-in-law avoids them as far as possible even when he is wearing a skin. A son-in-law must also—at any rate in some parts of Nuerland—wear sandals when visiting his mother-in-law, as he is dangerous to her should he visit her bare-footed and might cause her to become barren. There are various other customs indicating the mother-in-law to son-in-law relationship, such as the obligation on the survivor, should either die, to visit the grave a few days after burial and throw a bracelet on it. Also a son-in-law must not visit his parents-in-law when they are sick, and they must not visit him when he is sick. A man avoids his mother-in-law and her attitude to him is one of shyness and reserve. Unlike fathers-in-law and brothers-in-law, who ask a husband directly for whatever they want, a mother-in-law trusts that her son-in-law will remember her wants or, if in great need, asks him for a gift through her daughter. The mother-in-law relationship among the Nuer is a subject of mirth, and the foulest slips of the tongue are attributed to mothers-in-law when talking to their daughters' husbands.

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All these rules regulating the behaviour of a man to his parents-in-law, and the avoidance and the attitude of reserve which accompany them, are eased after the birth of a second child and slowly  101 break down as patterns of affinity change into patterns of kinship, the husband becoming 'the father of our daughter's children' instead of 'our daughter's husband'. A man may even joke with his mother-in-law when there are several children.

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